

Section A: Research methods and researching social inequalities

In this section, learners are introduced to a range of methods and sources of data as well as the factors influencing the design of sociological research and the relationship between theory and methods. Learners are encouraged to consider the practical, ethical and theoretical issues arising in sociological research and to apply knowledge of research methods to the particular context of social inequalities.

Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. What is the relationship between theory and methods?	Positivism: • patterns • trends • objectivity • value freedom • quantitative data Interpretivism: • meanings and experiences • verstehen and empathy • rapport • subjectivity • researcher imposition • reflexivity • qualitative data Key research concepts: • validity • reliability • representativeness • generalisability	understand how social research is guided by theory. use these concepts in an evaluative way when considering the research process and methodological theories.

Key questions	Content	Learners should:
2. What are the main stages of the research process?	Key concepts in the research process: • factors influencing the choice of research topic • aims/hypothesis/research questions • primary data • secondary data • operationalisation • pilot studies • data collection • respondent validation • longitudinal studies • interpretation of data • the relationship between sociology and social policy Sampling process Sampling techniques • random • systematic • stratified • snowball • volunteer • opportunity • purposive • quota Access and gatekeeping Ethics	consider how sociological research contributes to social policy. understand the practical, ethical and theoretical factors influencing choice of sampling process. understand the advantages and disadvantages of random and non-random sampling techniques. understand how samples are accessed and the issues with access. understand ethical considerations such as those used by the British Sociological Association and why ethical principles should be followed.

Key questions	Content	Learners should:
3. Which methods are used in sociological research?	Research methods: • questionnaires • structured interviews • statistical data (official and non-official) • content analysis • observations (participant, non-participant, covert, overt) • unstructured interviews • semi structured interviews • ethnography Quantitative and qualitative data Mixed methods • triangulation • methodological pluralism	consider the uses of research methods in the context of social inequalities.